Lesson 39: Reporting Verbs and Quoting: Ellipses and Square Brackets

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 4: Research and Evidence

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 4.10 Language Toolkit; 4.11 Takeaways.

In this lesson

You review the grammar of reporting words: which ones take a "that" clause, which take a noun phrase, and which have special patterns such as "asks whether" or "writes about". You also learn to shorten and clarify quotations with ellipses and square brackets without changing their meaning. Finally, you look back at the whole unit and revise your research paragraph, so that your evidence reads accurately and smoothly.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Choose a reporting word for the kind of idea it introduces (opinion, fact, concession).
- Use the correct grammar pattern after a reporting word.
- Punctuate a direct quotation after a reporting word.
- Use ellipses and square brackets correctly, without changing the meaning of a quotation.
- Reflect on how you use and cite evidence.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
SVC	subject + verb + complement: a complete idea	(He asserts that) bilingualism is valuable.
noun phrase (NP)	a noun and the words attached to it, not a complete sentence	the health and legal aspects of decriminalization
asserts	states firmly that something is true	Le asserts that drugs should be decriminalized.
notes	notices or pays careful attention to something, often not the main idea	Le notes that the end of Prohibition did not result in greater alcohol abuse.
claims	states something, especially with little proof (it can show that you doubt it)	Opponents claim that drug use will increase with decriminalization.
speculates	guesses about possible causes or effects	Le speculates that the initial transition period might be difficult.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
challenges	argues against; refuses to believe	Ruiz challenges the assumption that decriminalization encourages drug use.
acknowledges	admits something, often something that supports the other side	Kaur acknowledges some risks of the new policy.
independent clause	a clause with a subject and verb that can stand alone	Nguyen proposes a different idea
ellipsis (plural: ellipses)	three periods with a space between them (. . .) that show words were left out	far too many . . . children of immigrants
square brackets	[ ] around words you added or changed inside a quotation	In [Snow's] view

Rules and explanations

Reporting words signal meaning

After "argues", readers expect an opinion; after "reports", a fact; after "acknowledges", a concession. Be careful with "believes" and "thinks": we can read authors' words, not their minds. And if you use "claims" for someone's opinion, readers will think you doubt it.

Five grammar patterns

Pattern	Reporting words	Example
1. verb + that + SVC	agrees (that), argues that, asserts (that), believes (that), cautions that, claims (that), concludes that, insists (that), notes that, reports that, says (that), speculates that, states that, thinks (that)	She warns that this law will have terrible consequences.
2. verb + NP (or a "how" or "whether" clause, or verb-ing), never "that"	challenges, considers, criticizes, describes, discusses, examines, investigates, refers to, summarizes	The author questions the motives behind English-only policies.
3. either pattern 1 or pattern 2	acknowledges, adds, admits, comments that / comments on, explains, indicates, maintains, mentions, points out, proposes, remembers, recalls, regrets, suggests	Kaur acknowledges that the new policy has some risks. / Kaur acknowledges some risks of the new policy.
4. special patterns	asks if/whether/why + SVC, asks about + NP; questions + NP, questions if/whether + SVC; recommends that + SVC (base verb), recommends + verb-ing; writes that + SVC, writes about + NP; wonders if/whether/why + SVC, wonders about + NP	Kim asks why current policies continue, despite evidence that they are not working.

Pattern	Reporting words	Example
5. according to + source, SVC	a prepositional phrase, not a verb	According to Kim, decriminalization is the first step toward solving the drug crisis.

- "(that)" in parentheses means "that" is optional; using it sounds more formal. Without parentheses, include "that" in academic writing.
- Pattern 2: to add a complete idea, use "the fact that", "with", or an adjective clause, without making the noun the subject of a sentence: The author describes an **experiment** that tested methods of memorization.
- "According to" can go at the beginning, in the middle or at the end of the sentence. Never add a reporting verb for the same idea.

Reporting a direct quotation

With a full-sentence quotation, leave out "that" and use commas. The reporting word can go before the quotation, inside it (after the subject of the first sentence) or after it. (When a quoted phrase becomes part of your own sentence, "that" stays: Bak maintains that "the detractors have made errors in their experimental methods.") Use a colon only after an independent clause:

- Nguyen proposes, "The city should adopt harm reduction approaches."
- Nguyen proposes a different idea: "The city should adopt harm reduction approaches."

Ellipses: leaving words out

- An ellipsis is three periods with a space between them (. . .). It shows that you left out words to make a quotation shorter and simpler.
- In the book's example from Catherine Snow, repetitive words are left out: "Notably, far too many . . . children of immigrants . . . lose fluency in their parents' language. . . . By the third generation, immigrants have completely lost fluency in their heritage languages" (Snow). When the gap comes after the end of a sentence, the sentence's period comes first, then the ellipsis.
- Do not change the meaning. "Notably, . . . children with the greatest potential . . . have completely lost fluency in their heritage languages" is wrong: Snow says this about the third generation of immigrants.
- Check that your sentence is still grammatical. Do not leave out the grammar and function words that the sentence needs.

Square brackets: changing or adding words

- Use square brackets [like this] when the grammar of a quotation does not fit your sentence, or to make something clear. In the book's example, Ervin-Tripp "found that women [who were bilingual in English and Japanese] ended the sentences [which researchers gave them to complete] very differently depending on which language was used."
- To change a word at the beginning of a quotation, start the quotation later. In the same example, "She" is replaced by Ervin-Tripp's name before the quotation marks, so no brackets are needed.

- Do not change the meaning: "asking them [whether or not] to finish sentences" is not acceptable.

> **Psychology note:** In APA style (psychology), a direct quotation needs the author, the year and the page number, for example (Smith, 2020, p. 12).

Unit review

In this unit you learned to use evidence to support claims, decide when you need a citation, work carefully from sources to join a "conversation" with published writers, introduce evidence with reporting words and context, avoid plagiarism, and format a paper in MLA style.

Practice

Exercise 1. Grammar patterns. Complete each sentence with **that**, **about**, **on**, **if/whether**, or nothing (–).

1. Kim recommends _____ governments focus on treatment, not punishment.
2. Kaur comments _____ a new therapy that has been more successful in treating addiction.
3. Kim asks _____ spending more on prevention would be more effective.
4. Kim writes _____ the effects of criminalization.
5. Ruiz criticizes _____ the policy of imprisoning nonviolent drug offenders.
6. Le cautions _____ if drugs are not decriminalized, more violence will result.
7. Kim wonders _____ the efficacy of prosecuting drug users.
8. Kim questions _____ current policies are working.
9. Ruiz describes _____ a clinic in Vancouver that provides clean needles to addicts.
10. Kaur explains _____ the new therapy combines medical treatment with social support.

Exercise 2. Correct or incorrect? Correct the sentences that have a mistake.

1. According to Kim argues that decriminalization is the first step toward solving the drug crisis.
2. Harm reduction, according to a recent meta-analysis of over 70 studies, is the best strategy.
3. The author discusses that immigrants cannot return to their prior professions.
4. Le argues drugs should be decriminalized.
5. Kim points out stable crime rates in states where marijuana has been legalized.
6. Kim suggests to decriminalize drug use.
7. Kaur mentions prescription drug abuse, another related problem that cannot be ignored.
8. The inmate regrets losing custody of her child.

Exercise 3. Checking ellipses and square brackets. These quotations are from "The True Failure of Foreign Language Instruction" by Catherine Snow. Decide if each example uses square brackets and/or ellipses correctly. (In the original, the sentence begins "In my view, it's ironic that ..." and continues exactly as in item 1.)

1. In fact, "In [Snow's] view, it's ironic that we have students walking up staircases at one end of their school building to attend Spanish foreign language classes while at the other end of the same building native Spanish speakers are being taught English and content in ways that lead to their loss of Spanish" (Snow).
2. In fact, "it's ironic that we have students walking up staircases at one end of their school building to attend Spanish foreign language classes . . . being taught English and content in ways that lead to their loss of Spanish" (Snow).
3. Snow writes, "native Spanish speakers are being taught English and content in [order to] . . . lead to their loss of Spanish" (Snow).

Exercise 4. Use ellipses and brackets. These sentences are from Rebecca Callahan's article (Lesson 36).

1. "Then, in the late 1990s, research emerged showing that even when controlling on working memory, bilingual children display significantly greater attentional control to problem-solving tasks than monolingual children." Quote the part from "research emerged" to the end, but leave out "even when controlling on working memory".
2. "It's something we should cherish, not eradicate." ("It" means the home language of immigrants' children.) Quote this so that readers know what "it" is.
3. "Not only have these now-monolingual young adults lost the cognitive resources bilingualism provides, but they are less likely to be employed full-time, and earn less than their peers." Quote only the part after "but", and make clear who "they" are.

Speak with your tutor

- "Check my answers to Exercise 4. Did I change the meaning of any quotation?"
- "Give me ten reporting words from the lesson, one at a time. For each one, I will say a sentence about my research topic with the correct grammar pattern. Correct me."
- "Let's discuss the book's reflection questions: How does integrating evidence relate to 'sampling' in music? How do we use evidence from other sources in everyday life?"
- "How does the U.S. academic style of using and citing evidence differ from academic writing in Arabic? Ask me about my experience and add your own points."
- "Let's look at the sample essay 'Heritage Languages' (4.2) together. I will choose one especially effective use of evidence and one less effective use, and explain why. Then tell me what you think."

Writing task

Your research project: polish your evidence. Revise your cited paragraph from Lessons 37 and 38.

1. Replace at least three reporting words with more precise ones from the lesson (at least one from pattern 2 or pattern 4).
2. Shorten at least one quotation with an ellipsis, or clarify it with square brackets.
3. Use "according to" correctly at least once.

4. Then write a short reflection (100-150 words) on one of the book's questions: How does the U.S. academic style of using and citing evidence differ from other language cultures?

Self-editing checklist:

- Each reporting word fits the kind of idea it introduces (fact, opinion, concession).
- Each reporting word has the correct pattern (that + SVC, a noun phrase, about, on, whether ...).
- "That" is included wherever it is not optional.
- There is no second reporting verb with "according to", and a complete sentence follows it.
- My ellipses are three spaced periods, and the sentence around them is grammatical.
- My ellipses and brackets do not change the meaning of the original.
- I start a quotation later rather than changing its first words.
- Every quotation still has its citation.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Catherine Snow, "The True Failure of Foreign Language Instruction" (The Conversation), the article quoted in this lesson: https://theconversation.com/the-true-failure-of-foreign-language-instruction-80352

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. that (needed in academic writing)
2. on ("about" is also heard, but "comments on" is the usual academic pattern)
3. if / whether
4. about ("on" is also correct: "writes on a topic")
5. – (nothing)
6. that
7. about
8. whether / if
9. – (nothing)
10. that

Exercise 2

1. Incorrect: According to Kim, decriminalization is the first step … **or** Kim argues that decriminalization is the first step …
2. Correct.
3. Incorrect ("discuss" takes a noun phrase): The author discusses the barriers for immigrants who cannot return to their prior professions. **or** The author discusses the fact that immigrants cannot return to their prior professions.
4. Not correct for academic writing ("that" is not optional after "argues"): Le argues that drugs should be decriminalized.
5. Correct.
6. Incorrect: Kim suggests decriminalizing drug use. **or** Kim suggests that governments should decriminalize drug use.
7. Correct.
8. Correct.

Exercise 3 (book)

1. Correct use of square brackets: "[Snow's]" replaces "my" so that the quotation fits the writer's sentence.
2. Not correct. Too much of the original sentence has been taken out, and the meaning changes: now the students in Spanish classes seem to be the ones losing their Spanish.
3. Not correct. The added words change the meaning: "in [order to]" says that losing Spanish is the purpose of the teaching, but the original says it is the result.

Exercise 4 (example answers)

1. Callahan writes that "research emerged showing that . . . bilingual children display significantly greater attentional control to problem-solving tasks than monolingual children."
2. Callahan argues that the home language of immigrants' children is "something we should cherish, not eradicate." (Start the quotation later, as the book advises. "[The home language is] something we should cherish, not eradicate" is also possible.)
3. Callahan reports that children of immigrants who have lost their home language "are less likely to be employed full-time, and earn less than their peers." **or** Callahan reports that "they [young adults who have lost their home language] are less likely to be employed full-time, and earn less than their peers."

My notes